

Light upon Light

*Essays in Islamic Thought and History
in Honor of Gerhard Bowering*

Edited by

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Pseudo-Shaykh Bahā'ī on the Supreme Name, a Safavid-Qajar Lettrist Classic

Matthew Melvin-Koushki

How vividly I remember my first formal introduction to lettrism (*ilm al-hurūf*)—at the hand, naturally, of Professor Bowering. It was the fall of 2006, and I had recently moved to New Haven to begin my doctoral work under his direction. On a typically crisp New England day, the trees riotous with color, we assembled for our reading seminar on Abū 'Abd al-Raḥmān Sulamī, the famed fifth/eleventh-century Iranian Sufi sage and traditionist, on whose major *tafsīr* our Doktorvater had been working for several years; he announced that we would be reading (or rather, philologically ransacking) Sulamī's *Sharḥ ma'ānī l-hurūf*.¹ We plumbed that lettrist treatise over a period of weeks; little did I then suspect that the science it treated would become the subject of my dissertation, and thence the core of my broader scholarly vision to the present. Although there and elsewhere I have inveighed against the reflexive disappearing of the occult sciences, including lettrism, into Sufism,² that encounter with Sulamī, the Sufi lettrist, was nothing if not fateful.

Speaking of fate: in a nice bit of synchronicity (*az gharāyib-i ittifāqāt*), it just so happens that the first Arabic-Islamicate text I ever managed to slog through, back in Amman in 1998, with a new Hans Wehr to hand, was Sulamī's history of Sufism, *Ṭabaqāt al-ṣūfiyya*. Curious, no?

1 For a translation and study of this treatise, see, of course, Bowering, Sulamī's treatise.

2 See e.g. Melvin-Koushki, *Quest*; Melvin-Koushki, *World as* (Arabic) text. This is not to suggest that these two distinct intellectual-cultural currents did not intersect and fuse in culturally productive ways; as Noah Gardiner has shown, it was precisely the *sanctification* of lettrism in particular, this through its association with Ibn al-'Arabī and al-Būnī in Mamluk Cairo and Damascus during the seventh/thirteenth and eighth/fourteenth centuries, that propelled it to mainstream status from the ninth/fifteenth century onward. Gardiner, *Esotericism in a manuscript culture*. This sanctification process similarly encompassed a number of other occult sciences, including alchemy and geomancy, whereby they, too, were increasingly classified as the sciences of *walāya*; at the same time, they remained a standard and significant subset of the natural and mathematical sciences, and especially the latter. Melvin-Koushki, *Powers of one*.

In tribute to Gerhard Bowering, then, who set me—unintentionally, and at times to his dismay!—on the straight path of Islamic occultism studies, few offerings could be more fitting than a philological exercise in the history of lettrism. Such an exercise follows. Building on my work on Timurid-Turkmen-Safavid Iran, I here take the example of Shaykh Bahā'ī, Safavid *shaykh al-islām* and renaissance man extraordinaire, to whom was attributed by or in the Qajar era a curious lettrist *maṣnavī* on the Supreme Name (*dar rumūz-i ism-i a'zam*) that remains in wide circulation to the present.³ Indeed, that the eminent aya-tollah Ḥasan Ḥasanzāda Āmulī (b. 1928) saw fit to write a commentary treatise on this poem as recently as 1979 suggests it as a going Twelver scholarly, as well as popular, concern.⁴ But the different versions that circulate, in print and online, are all highly textually corrupt; while lettrist works of any era are frequently cryptic, to be sure, the lettrist procedures it hints at are obscure even to experienced scholars and specialists like Ḥasanzāda Āmulī, author of occult-scientific works in his own right.

The problem this odd yet enduringly popular text presents is thus first and foremost a philological one; but its analysis naturally debouches, I submit, onto themes of central importance to the intellectual, cultural, and even political history of Safavid Iran, as well as their reverberations and transformations in Qajar Iran and indeed in the Islamic Republic. I therefore here undertake to establish a more coherent version of the text as a basis for such analysis; provide an annotated translation to open it to specialists unfamiliar with lettrism; and briefly situate it in its originary Safavid-Qajar contexts. As I will confirm, this poem cannot be considered authentic; yet it does authentically represent the high Safavid culture of which Shaykh Bahā'ī was such a pivotal exponent and architect—as well as the Qajar scholarly and popular imaginary, naturally somewhat garbled, of that culture over two centuries later. For the bulk of the text is haphazardly extracted from a longer lettrist *maṣnavī*, the *Kunūz al-asmā'*

3 Most notably, it is included in standard editions of Shaykh Bahā'ī's divan; see e.g. al-Āmilī, *Kullīyyāt*, ed. Javāhirī 93–99 (the editor does note its doubtful attribution). For other versions see below. Note that the *Khavāṣṣ-i asmā-yi ilāhī* attributed to Shaykh Bahā'ī and preserved as MS Majlis 319/12 (158–162) is presumably the same work, as is the brief didactic poem on the active properties of letters preserved as MS Malik 3505/5 (fols. 29a–38b, copied 1301/1883), which appears from its incipit and explicit to be a truncated version of the same. See Naṣrābādī, *Kitābshināsī* 627–628, no. 38. That the latter occurs in a *majmū'a* of occult-scientific works opening with a Persian treatise by Ibn Turka on the same topic is of particular salience in the present context.

4 Ḥasanzāda Āmulī, *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 371–425. See also Ḥasanzāda Āmulī, *Durūs-i hay'at* ii, 794.

(Namehoards), by Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī (fl. 1576), Shaykh Bahā'ī's teacher in the occult sciences and the most prolific Persian author on lettrism of the tenth/sixteenth century.⁵

Dihdār, in short, fairly epitomizes Safavid lettrist culture;⁶ and Shaykh Bahā'ī would seem to have been his greatest student. That our author wrote a rather popular commentary on his own poem, the *Javāhir al-asrār*, therefore makes it possible to discern precisely in what scientific and literary respects alike its Qajar bowdlerization departs from Dihdār's original. Such departures may in turn suggest a broader degree of intellectual-historical discontinuity between the Safavid and Qajar eras—but a discontinuity nonetheless rooted in a common textual tradition of remarkable continuity, and one that persists, at least in contemporary Twelver scholarly circles, even in the all-rupturing teeth of colonialist-capitalist modernity.

As for the Safavid intellectual-imperial context, this offering acts as supplement to my forthcoming book *The occult science of empire in Aqqayunlu-Safavid Iran: Two Shirazi lettrists and their manuals of magic*, which features Maḥmūd Dihdār as one of the two case studies of the title; it also neatly slots into the framework developed by Kathryn Babayan in her landmark *Mystics, monarchs, and messiahs: Cultural landscapes of early modern Iran*,⁷ as well as the work of Cornell Fleischer and Azfar Moin on the contemporary Ottoman and Mughal imperial contexts respectively,⁸ and Evrim Binbaş's and my own on the Timurid.⁹ It is likewise conceived of as a modest contribution to Shaykh Bahā'ī studies. Unlike all other treatments of this towering figure to date, however, the present study takes seriously his reputation—one that began to grow in his own lifetime and burgeoned after his death—as *the most powerful practicing occultist of his generation*.¹⁰ For all its faults, the text at hand has propagated to

5 On this author see Melvin-Koushki, Maḥmūd Dehdār Shīrāzī; Melvin-Koushki, *Occult science of empire*.

6 Equally influential, if decidedly less *scientific*, was the lettrist cosmological approach of Rajab al-Bursī (d. 1411); see Melvin-Koushki, Safavid Twelver lettrism.

7 Babayan, *Mystics, monarchs, and messiahs*.

8 See e.g. Fleischer, *Ancient wisdom*; Moin, *Millennial sovereign*.

9 Binbaş, *Intellectual networks*; Melvin-Koushki, *Quest*.

10 Emblematic of the materialist-positivist valorization of Shaykh Bahā'ī in modern scholarship, wherein his occult-scientific interests are wholly elided, is C.E. Bosworth's list of his many professional roles (*Bahā' al-Dīn al-Āmilī* 12): "eminent theologian, philosopher, Qur'ān commentator, jurist, astronomer, teacher, poet and engineer." For a (similarly occultophobic) overview of Shaykh Bahā'ī's life, character, sociopolitical impact, and scholarly output see 'Abbās, *Bahā' al-Dīn al-Āmilī*. For the state of the field of Shaykh Bahā'ī studies see Stewart, *Brief history of scholarship*, and Stewart's numerous studies reprinted in the same volume; and Stewart, *Bahā' al-Dīn al-Āmilī*.

the present because it helps sustain that legend, and indeed shows it to have a substantial core of historical truth.

1 Safavid Philosophy as Occult-Scientific Practice

In recent decades, and watered by the labors of Henry Corbin in particular, the study of Safavid philosophy has emerged as a fertile subfield in its own right; it is routinely identified by specialists and nonspecialists alike as the early modern culmination of Islamicate metaphysical thought in its grand synthesis of all preceding philosophical, theological, and mystical currents—Avicennan, Illuminationist, Sufi, Sunni, Shi'i.¹¹ We now have a general picture of the intellectual and religious commitments of the most prominent Safavid philosophers, including in the first place Mullā Ṣadrā Shīrāzī (d. 1635) and his teachers, and their crucial role in the creation of a new Safavid imperial Twelver Shi'i culture is universally acknowledged. We understand that the central focus of many Safavid thinkers is Neoplatonic *theosis* (*ta'alluh*), aka *theomimesis* (*tashabbuh bi-l-bārī*), a concept signaling adherence to a specific set of ascetic-mystical practices aimed at purifying the mind and body and preparing them for transcendence.¹² But the history of the *practice* of Safavid philosophy has yet to be written; quite simply, we have little idea how its exponents lived their systems, how they constructed this new society.¹³

While our ignorance in this respect is a problem besetting the study of Islamicate philosophy in general, it is especially hobbling with respect to its Safavid subset. For the tenor of Safavid philosophy is strongly Neoplatonic in most respects, as is widely recognized;¹⁴ less recognized is the fact that, in practical terms, this philosophical commitment entailed an embrace of the Neoplatonic notion of sage (*ḥakīm*) as *occultist architect of the world*, theurgic invoker of the celestial and the divine through practices expressly magical in order to

11 Naturally, individual scholars have emphasized certain of these elements over others according to personal taste and training; Sajjad Rizvi identifies, for instance, four distinct approaches to Mullā Ṣadrā: esotericist, comparativist, Avicennist, and Iranian nativist. Rizvi, *Mullā Ṣadrā and metaphysics* 6–14.

12 Ibid. 24–26.

13 Rizvi, *Philosophy as a way of life* 44.

14 On this Neoplatonic turn see Pourjavady and Schmidtke, *Eastern renaissance?*; Rizvi, *(Neo)Platonism revived*.

understand—and shape—reality. That is to say, an investment in the occult sciences (*al-ʿulūm al-gharība*) was not only considered unproblematic by the majority of Safavid scholarly elites, but in fact indispensable to the practice of Neoplatonic philosophy.¹⁵ This point has long been appreciated by specialists of Late Antique or Renaissance Neoplatonism; but persistent scholarly positivism and occultophobia, on the one hand, and the Corbinian insistence on disappearing occultism into the uselessly flabby and expressly apolitical categories of “mysticism” and “esotericism,” on the other, means that this basic aspect of philosophical practice in Safavid Iran has yet to be acknowledged, much less studied.

The equally strong *Neopythagorean* tenor of Safavid philosophy is also routinely elided in the literature, and for similar reasons. Here again, it is well known among specialists that Neopythagoreanism as a distinct Late Antique philosophical current was effectively fused with Neoplatonism from Plotinus and Iamblichus onward (to the everlasting annoyance of Aristotelians). As such, the great resurgence of Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean-occultist thought in fifteenth–seventeenth-century Europe known as the Renaissance featured the lionization of Pythagoras, father of *philosophia* itself, as preeminent model of *sage-as-mage*, (occult) scientist and mystic in equal measure.¹⁶ The Neopythagorean cosmogonic doctrine positing number as the first and most fundamental principle of the universe, the intellect’s sole vehicle of return to the One, accordingly became foundational to early modern Christianate philosophy-science. This led in turn to the celebrated *mathematization of the cosmos*, a quest that culminated with Isaac Newton’s (d. 1727) *Principia mathematica*, universally hailed as the basis for “scientific modernity.”

Yet Pythagoras was lionized in precisely the same fashion by Safavid philosophers, antiquarianist-perennialists to a man; his synthesis of metaphysical speculation and mystical-magical practice was highly salient to those thinkers who sought to do the same. Given its Neopythagorean bent, therefore, we should expect Safavid philosophy to be characterized by a certain mathematizing tendency—and hence a commitment to *lettrism*, together with astrology

15 This rubric, meaning those sciences that are unusual, rare, or difficult—i.e., elite sciences—, includes astrology, alchemy, and a variety of magical and divinatory techniques, routinely designated as such in encyclopedias of the sciences, chronicles, biographical dictionaries, theological and legal tracts, etc.; less frequently used terms in the Persianate context are *ʿulūm khafīyya* or *ghāmiḍa*, sciences that are hidden or occult. Its nineteenth-century European flavor notwithstanding, the term “occultism” is here used to denote to a scholarly investment in one or more of the occult sciences.

16 See e.g. Celenza, Pythagoras in the Renaissance.

and geomancy, as a primary occult-scientific application of mathematics by the Safavid period, and the chiefest expression of Islamic Neopythagoreanism.¹⁷

Enter Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad al-Āmilī (d. 1621), aka Shaykh Bahā'ī. Widely famed as an authority on astronomy and the mathematical sciences, quite literally an architect of the new Safavid imperial capital of Isfahan and a founding member of its new philosophical school, the Baalbeki sage manifestly sought to incarnate this dual Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean ideal.¹⁸ That this ideal entailed the heavy use of the occult sciences—especially as a preferred means of *Shi'izing Iran*¹⁹—is confirmed by a wide range of contemporary sources, from chronicles and biographical dictionaries to philosophical-scientific treatises and encyclopedias of the sciences.

Three programmatic works may here be considered representative. Especially revealing is the schema offered by Abū l-Qāsim Anṣārī Kāzirūnī (fl. 1605), a prominent Shirazi scholar in the service, like Shaykh Bahā'ī, of Shah 'Abbās the Great (r. 1587–1629); this Kāzirūnī does in his *Sullam al-samāwāt* (Ladder to the heavens), which eclectic Persian work is devoted to constructing an intellectual-religious pedigree for his patron that is simultaneously Twelver Shi'i, Sufi, and occultist. To this end, the *Sullam* includes a long chapter taxonomizing the occult sciences as a subset not of the natural or mathematical sciences, as they were usually classified from al-Fārābī and Ibn Sīnā onward,

17 This is particularly pronounced in the work of Mīr Dāmād, explicitly following Ibn Turka; see Melvin-Koushki, *World as (Arabic) text*. On the process whereby various occult sciences were gradually mathematicalized in classifications of the sciences (sg. *taṣnīf al-ʿulūm*) between the fourth/tenth and eleventh/seventeenth centuries in the Persianate world more generally, and its intimate intellectual-sociological connection to the parallel but far more celebrated mathematization of astronomy, see Melvin-Koushki, *Powers of one*; Melvin-Koushki, *Of Islamic grammatology*.

18 As Tunikābunī remarks in his *Qīṣaṣ al-ʿulamāʾ* (295), “The Shaykh had an absolute mastery of most sciences, and was an exceptional mathematician in particular.” The latter is the author of works on astronomy, including *Tashrīḥ al-aflāk* (Anatomy of the heavens), in Persian, and *Risāla fī Taqārīs al-arḍ* (On the topographical features of the earth), a supercommentary on one section of Qāzizāda Rūmī's commentary on Chaghminī's *Epitome of astronomy*. In the field of mathematics, his *Baḥr al-ḥisāb* on arithmetic and its abridgement *Khulāṣat al-ḥisāb* were quite popular as teaching texts for centuries. On his works in both fields see e.g. Abisaab, *Converting Persia* 171; Qaṣrī, *Sīmāʾī az Shaykh Bahā'ī* 97–132; Bābāpūr, *Nigāhī bi Āṣār-i Riyāzi-yi Shaykh Bahā'ī*. On the mathematicalization of the occult sciences—a process that culminated precisely during Shaykh Bahā'ī's lifetime—see Melvin-Koushki, *Powers of one*.

19 Dihdār's lettrism, for instance, while smoothly continuous with Timurid Sunni precedent, involves the talismanic harnessing of the Fourteen Infallibles (*chahārdah maʿšūm*) for political and other ends; see e.g. his *Zubdat al-abvāḥ* (Choicest talismans), edited and translated in Melvin-Koushki, *Occult science of empire*.

but exclusively of *walāya*, here presented as Sufi-style sainthood rather than a Twelver theological category.²⁰ Similarly, the *Riyāz al-abrār* (Gardens of the righteous) of Ḥusayn ‘Aqīlī Rustamdārī, a comprehensive Persian encyclopedia written in Qazvin in 1571 for Shah Ṭahmāsb (r. 1524–1576) and treating of some 90 sciences in systematic fashion, features both a strong Twelver flavor and a heavy emphasis on the occult sciences. Most significantly, therein Rustamdārī, too, breaks with precedent to reclassify two occult sciences—astrology (*‘ilm al-nujūm*) and geomancy (*‘ilm al-raml*)—as mathematical, while strongly implying that most of the other occult sciences transcend even that category in their connection to the Imams as sole vectors of *walāya*, including in the first place lettrism (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*) and alchemy (*‘ilm al-kīmīyā*).²¹

Finally, the philosophical *summa* of Mīr Dāmād (d. 1631), foremost philosopher of his generation and Shaykh Bahā’ī’s close colleague, likewise penned at the request of Shah ‘Abbās: titled *Jazavāt u mavāqīt* (Firebrands and epiphanies) in intimation of its author’s Illuminationist proclivities, this remarkable Persian work presents its royal patron with a new, explicitly Twelver, perennialist-antiquarianist, Neoplatonic-Neopythagorean philosophy—one whose primary scientific application is precisely lettrism. For all that this basic feature of Mīr Dāmād’s thought has been lost on modern scholarship, it was still duly appreciated by Qajar philosophers, and the circle of Mullā ‘Alī Nūrī (d. 1831) in particular. That great reviver of Sadrian philosophy thoroughly glossed both this and Mīr Dāmād’s *Nibrās al-ḍiyā’ wa-taswā’ al-sawā’* (Lamp of illumination and keeping the balance), another openly lettrist work, together with the seminal *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* (Book of inquiries) of Ibn Turka (d. 1432), their primary source.²² As for the sage of Astarabad himself, he was clearly more concerned with theory than with practice, in rather sharp contrast to his enterprising polymath colleague Shaykh Bahā’ī, and does not figure in the sources as a major occultist. But Mīr Dāmād’s comprehensive Neopythagoreanization of Safavid philosophy provided a robust epistemological framework in which Safavid occult science could and did flourish. And this philosopher, too, does seem to have been willing to practice his theory at certain critical junctures; Mīr Dāmād’s great-grandson Mīr Muḥammad Ashraf ‘Alawī (d. 1718)

20 Kāzīrūnī, *Sullam al-samāwāt* 81–130.

21 This encyclopedia is unpublished; see Melvin-Koushki, Powers of one 166–168. Mīr Find-iriskī (d. 1640), close colleague to Mīr Dāmād and Shaykh Bahā’ī both, was particularly invested in the latter science, though of course his alchemical works likewise remain unpublished.

22 Mīr Dāmād, *Jazavāt u mavāqīt*; Mīr Dāmād, *Nibrās al-ḍiyā’*; Melvin-Koushki, Quest 80–81, 113, 437, 573–574.

famously credits him, for instance, with saving Iran from Ottoman invasion by means of a lettrist invocation.²³

2 Shaykh Bahā'ī as Safavid Mage

I am without peer in this era, the one
whose glory is sung by the Scribe of Glory
and inscribed on every building!
Wherever you go you hear tell of me,
in every country my mention is current.

SHAYKH BAHĀ'Ī²⁴

As quintessential Safavid Neopythagoreanizing sage, then, it is hardly surprising that Shaykh Bahā'ī comes off in contemporary and later sources as precisely one of the most powerful *mages* of the early modern era. From the Safavid period to the Qajar, and the Qajar to the present, he was and is celebrated as master of the talismanic magic square, seasoned spellcaster, seer of the unseen, author of fearful illusions. But how did this sage-mage learn his practical lettrist arts? At the hand, some later sources suggest, of Maḥmūd Dihdār himself.²⁵

Regardless of the probability of a personal connection between the two men, however high, Maḥmūd Dihdār's manuals of letter magic and letter divination represent the state of the art in Safavid Iran during the second half of the tenth/sixteenth century, and as such would certainly have been absorbed by a polymath as voracious and unrelenting as Shaykh Bahā'ī. The open acclaim of his mastery of the occult sciences, even in official Safavid chronicles, thus provides a counterweight to the curious silence surrounding Maḥmūd Dihdār's career. Iskandar Beg Munshī (d. 1633), court historian to Shah 'Abbās, indites in

23 Ja'fariyān, *Naqsh-i khāndān* 409–410. As to the enduringly popular association of Mīr Dāmād with Shaykh Bahā'ī precisely in lettrist terms, an anecdote related by Nāẓim al-Islām Kirmānī (d. 1919), the renowned chronicler of the Iranian Constitutional Revolution, is representative: he reports having met, in Shawwāl 1326 (October–November 1908), a certain individual who claimed to be in possession of a talismanic shirt prepared by the two great Safavid scholars for Shah 'Abbās, with the virtue of rendering its wearer bulletproof. Kirmānī, *Tārīkh-i bidārī-yi Īrānīyān*, 235–236.

24 Al-'Āmilī, *Kullīyyāt*, ed. Kātibī 71 (ghazal: *agar kunam gila-yi man az zamāna-yi ghidār: man ān yağāna-yi dahr-am ki vaṣf-i faẓl-i ma-rā / nivishta munshī-yi qudrat bi har dar u divār // bi har diyār ki ā'ī ishārati shīnuvī / bi har kujā ravī zikr-i man buvad dar kār*).

25 See e.g. Mīr-Jahānī Ṭabāṭabā'ī, *Ravāyih al-nasamāt* 100.

encomium: Shaykh Bahā'ī, the ultimate scholar, is “possessed of eternal forms of knowledge (*‘ārif-i ma‘ārif-i azalī*), a master of sciences occult and manifest (*vāqif-i ‘ulūm-i khafī u jalī*).”²⁶ Shaykh Bahā'ī's student and servitor (*khādim*) Ḥusayn b. Ḥaydar al-Karakī al-Āmilī (fl. 1621) is reported to have said of his teacher: “He was exceptional in his knowledge of certain sciences [i.e., the occult sciences] that were ignored by (*lam yaḥum ḥawla-hā*) his contemporaries, and even by his predecessors as far as I know, among both elite and nonelite scholars.”²⁷

As noted, moreover, his reputation as an outstanding occultist has remained intact down to the present, or rather grown considerably. Writing in the high Qajar period, Mīrzā Muḥammad b. Sulaymān Tunikābunī (d. 1885) offers account upon account of the Shaykh's wonderworking ways: his miracles (*karā-māt*) include conversation with the dead, the creation of dragons, and the taming of lions.²⁸ His magic squares are reported to have protected Shiraz and Isfahan from the plague for centuries:

It is widely known that Shaykh Bahā'ī engraved a magic square (*mu-rabba'*) or other figure on a stone and buried it on Iran's frontier in the vicinity of Shiraz to defend against the woe of pestilence (*vabā*), which was thereby prevented from entering Iran from the time of the Shaykh to that of Fath 'Alī Shāh (r. 1797–1834), when Prince Ḥusayn-'Alī Mīrzā was governor of Shiraz and all the princes had designs on the throne and were therefore preoccupied with amassing money. The English were thus able to buy the stone from the prince-governor of Shiraz for 120,000 tomans,²⁹ who, out of his lust for wealth, turned a blind eye to Iran and its people, forgetting—*Say: O God, Master of the kingdom!* (Q 3:26)—that kingship is in God's hand alone. In any event, after the stone was sold pestilence came to Iran, and the plague (*ṭā'ūn*) followed; and to this day most years see an outbreak of plague. The Shaykh is also known to have constructed another magic square and buried it in the vicinity of Isfahan to defend against plague, and from that day to this it has not struck the city. Even

26 Iskandar Beg Munshī, *Ālam-ārā-yi 'Abbāsī* ii, 967. Cf. Kāshifī's definition of the division between the two types of sciences in the preface to his *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, or 'Alī Ṣafī's in his abridgement *Tuḥfa-yi khānī* (MS Majlis 12575/2, 273–284: 274): occult sciences (*'ulūm-i khafīyya*) are those sciences that are not freely discussable in madrasa or majlis settings, as they must be kept from the unworthy (*nā-maḥramān*).

27 Khwānsārī, *Rawḍāt al-jannāt* vii, 58; quoted in Nūrī, *Mustadrak al-wasā'il* xx, 228; and al-Muhājir, *Sittat fuqahā' abtāl* 269–270.

28 Tunikābunī, *Qīṣaṣ al-'ulamā'* 291, 293–294; Ishkavarī, *Maḥbūb al-qulūb* ii, 407.

29 *Dah davāzdah hizār tūmān*.

during the year of the great plague that overtook all the cities of Iran, it did not visit Isfahan.³⁰

Even today in his hometown of Baalbek, the Shaykh's spells are still famous:

To this day locals relate the story that when the Shaykh was hosted at a house near the river that divides the town, in the neighborhood that is still called Ḥayy Āl Murtaḍā, he was so annoyed by the constant croaking of the frogs that he was driven to cast a spell (*waḍa'a raṣd^{an}*) that would silence them forever. And as it happens, one now never hears frogs croaking within the city limits despite their abundance in its waterways—an inexplicable phenomenon.³¹

Strange as all these feats might seem, they were firmly rooted in an inquiring scholarly mentality; as Muḥaddiṣ Nūrī (d. 1902) reassures us, in explanation of al-Karakī's encomium above: "The wondrous acts (*gharā'ib*) that would manifest from him at times ... were the products of these [occult] sciences."³² In this case, then, the fame of the student would seem to enlighten the relative obscurity of the teacher, Maḥmūd Dihdār—and the teacher's lettrist oeuvre the sociopolitical and indeed biological feats of his greatest student.

Apart from such reports and Maḥmūd Dihdār's oeuvre itself, perhaps our best source for understanding the role of occultism in Safavid society generally and Shaykh Bahā'ī's association therewith in particular is, significantly, a Timurid-era grimoire: the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* (Qasimian secrets) of Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī (d. 1505), Sabzavari preacher, polymath, and famed occultist. Purporting to be a Persian translation of two Arabic works on *sīmiyā* and *rīmiyā*, the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* does not appear to have been much read in the late ninth/fifteenth and the tenth/sixteenth centuries; but in the eleventh/seventeenth century its popularity blossomed. Testifying to the magic manual's new cachet, in the early decades of that century it was expanded to include briefer sections on the three sciences mentioned by the author but deliberately left aside: *kīmiyā*, *līmiyā*, and *hīmiyā*.³³

30 Tunikābunī, *Qīṣaṣ al-ʿulamāʾ* 295. On contemporary anti-plague letter magic—a primary application of the science for centuries—see e.g. the Ottoman plague treatises of ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī (d. 1454), Kemālpaşazāde Aḥmed (d. 1534), and Taşköprüzāde Aḥmed (d. 1561). Varlık, *Plague and empire* 11–12, 226–228, 233, 244.

31 Al-Muhājir, *Sittat fuqahāʾ abṭāl* 229–230. My thanks to Hussein Abdulsater for alerting me to these accounts.

32 Nūrī, *Mustadrak al-wasāʾil* ii, 228.

33 The definitive study to date of this seminal grimoire is Subtelny, Kāshifī's *Asrār-i qāsi-*

Most significant for our purposes here, the interpolated section on *līmīyā* (talismans) includes a wealth of detail as to the identities and activities of practitioners of letter magic during Shah ‘Abbās’s reign in particular—in effect, a who’s who of high Safavid occultism. The single most-cited authority is, not surprisingly, Shaykh Bahā’;³⁴ Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 1397), the great Tabrizi Kurdish lettrist-chemist of the late fourteenth century, teacher of Ibn Turka and primary model for Maḥmūd Dihdār, runs a close second.³⁵ Equally notably, the philosopher Mīr Ghiyāṣ al-Dīn Manṣūr Dashtakī (d. 1542) figures as personal lettrist to Shah Ṭahmāsb.³⁶ A number of other prominent scholars and shaykhs feature as master letter magicians,³⁷ and great emphasis is placed on

mī. That Safavid elite interest in the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* already was already evident in the early ninth/fifteenth century is indicated by the fact that Kāshifī’s son ‘Alī Šafī (d. 1533) produced a simplified version of this work in 1522 at the request of Durmish Khan Shāmlū (d. 1526), Safavid governor of Isfahan and then Herat; this version is titled *Tuḥfa-yi khānī*, aka *Kashf al-asrār*, and like its source treats only of *sīmīyā* and *rīmīyā* (see e.g. MS Majlis 1065/5, 175–256; Subtelny, Kāshifī’s *Asrār-i qāsimī*; Melvin-Koushki, Quest 272). For his part, Kāshifī Sr. defines *sīmīyā* as the manipulation of imaginal constructs (*khayālāt*), and *rīmīyā* as terrestrial magic (*shu‘badāt*). Although he lists three other related occult sciences in the preface—*kīmīyā*, or alchemy; *līmīyā*, or talismans; and *hīmīyā*, or astral magic—and various authorities and texts under the rubric of each, he explicitly states that the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* is conceived of as a translation-adaptation of two Arabic works in particular: the *K. Sīhr al-‘uyūn* of Abū ‘Abdallāh Maghribī (aka *Kitāb Ibn al-Ḥallāj*), and the treatise *‘Uyūn al-ḥaqā’iq wa-idāh al-ṭarā’iq* by the seventh/thirteenth-century alchemist Abū l-Qāsim Aḥmad al-‘Irāqī al-Simāwī (al-Simāwī) (*Asrār-i Qāsimī*, MS Majlis 12559/2, 52–167: 54–55; on the latter see Holmyard, Abu’ l-Qāsim al-‘Irāqī; Saif, Cows and the bees). (It should be noted here that Kāshifī always bases his works on others, though his exemplars are typically in Persian.) *Kūmīyā*, *līmīyā*, *hīmīyā*, *sīmīyā*, and *rīmīyā* often occur in a series, their initial letters being combined to produce the occultist motto “the whole is a secret” (*KLHSR* = *kullu-hu sirr*). Cf. ‘Allāma Ṭabāṭabā’ī’s (d. 1981) definition of these five sciences in his *Mizān* (i, 244); significantly for our purposes here, in the same section he quotes: “Said our Shaykh al-Bahā’ī: ‘The best book on these [five] arts is one I saw in the city of Herat titled *Kullu-hu Sirr*—a phrase derived from the first letter of each of these sciences’ names: *al-kīmīyā*, *al-līmīyā*, *al-hīmīyā*, *al-sīmīyā* and *al-rīmīyā*.”

34 See e.g. Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, lithograph 87, 98, 99, 102, 105; and Lory, Kāshifī’s *Asrār-i Qāsimī* 537. Given the exclusively Safavid tenor of the interpolated section in question, Lory’s identification of this Shaykh Bahā’ al-Dīn Muḥammad with Bahā’ al-Dīn Naqshband is obviously incorrect.

35 See e.g. Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, lithograph 98. On Akhlāṭī see Binbaş, *Intellectual networks* 114–140; Melvin-Koushki, Quest 47–57 and *passim*; on Akhlāṭī as Dihdār’s model see Melvin-Koushki, *Occult science of empire*.

36 He is mentioned more generally as a master talismanist; see e.g. Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, lithograph, Bombay 1883, 85, 92, 97, 104.

37 E.g., Mīrzā Jān Kāshgharī (86), ‘Abd al-Laṭīf Gilānī (90, 91, 97), Mīrzā Kāshānī (96), ‘Abd al-Šamad Ardabīlī (114, 116).

their prized and potent support of the various political actors of their day—even Ibn Sīnā (Shaykh Bū 'Alī) is cited as a lettrist to be feared.³⁸ The author of this section—most likely Shah 'Abbās's court astrologer-geomancer and historian Jalāl al-Dīn Munajjim Yazdī (d. 1619), as Maria Subtelny has shown—presents himself as a member of Shaykh Bahā'ī's scholarly circle, even reporting that the Shaykh once invited him to collaborate on the construction of a magic square at court.³⁹ That the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* has been attributed to Shaykh Bahā'ī himself is thus both unsurprising and significant.⁴⁰

Maḥmūd Dihdār, naturally, is one of the first authorities mentioned. In his case too his service to the Safavid ruling elite is the salient point:

On seeking an audience with kings (*dīdan-i mulūk*): One must inscribe a 4×4 square on gold and populate it with the numbers of the holy verse *God is All-gentle (latīf) with His servants, providing for whomsoever He will* (Q 42:19) [= 998], combining these with the letters of his own name. He should then insert the resulting number in the square, refraining from speech in the process. Of these two names [i.e., his own and the king's], he should write one at the top of the square and one at the bottom ...,⁴¹ and carry [the talisman] on his person. Thus when he sees the king he will be honored and shown generosity. This square was developed by Mawlānā

38 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, lithograph 89. On the Safavid transmogrification of Ibn Sīnā himself, the second father of peripateticism, into a Neopythagorean-occultist authority see Melvin-Koushki, *World as* (Arabic) text. Most famously, the important occultist manual *Kunūz al-mu'azzimīn* (Spellcasters' treasures) was likewise attributed to Ibn Sīnā well after the fact, presumably in the Safavid period (ed. J. Humā'ī, Tehran 1331 Sh./1952).

39 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī*, lithograph 93, 101; for a translation of this passage see Subtelny, Kāshifī's *Asrār-i qāsimī*.

40 'Abbās, *Bahā' al-Dīn al-Āmilī* 287; Nūrī, *Mustadrak al-wasā'il* xx, 228. The latter finds such an attribution offensive:

[Shaykh Bahā'ī's] popular reputation [for occult knowledge] grew to such a point that people attributed to him every kind of rare or strange act (*nādīra wa-gharība*)—the majority of such attributions being baseless and false. Indeed, one contemporary writer even went so far as to attribute to him the book *The Qasimian Secrets*, presuming it to be dictated by him to a man named Qāsim. Thus did a poor [scholar] make it seem as though this great scholar authorized the commission of great sins as prescribed in this book. [It instructs one], for example, to tie a cow up in a granary, have intercourse with it, then pour certain medicines in its vagina (among other such vain actions); this operation they call the Great Secret (*al-nāmūs al-akbar*), and assert that the parts of this cow when applied to the man [in question] allow him to achieve invisibility (*al-khafā'*) and other such operations.

On this (in)famous operation see Saif, *The Cows and the Bees*.

41 Two words here are indecipherable.

Maḥmūd Dihdār Shīrāzī, who constructed one for Amīr Khan;⁴² as a result he attained control over all of Fars (*imārat u iyālat-i Fārs-rā yāft*).⁴³

But lettrists were not simply props to power—they were also checks on that power. Here Shaykh Bahā'ī is presented as protecting hapless souls from royal wrath by exerting occult control over the shah's moods:

[On negating the anger of kings]: If a king becomes angry with someone such that the latter is at risk of execution, he should use this same number to inscribe this square on gold at an auspicious hour and donate some sweetmeats (*andakī shīrīnī*) to the poor; in the same hour the king's wrath will turn to graciousness and clemency. My own departed teacher saved many individuals from execution by virtue of this square, and Shaykh Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad [al-Āmilī] (may He sanctify his secret!) constructed one for Āqā 'Ināyat [Allāh], who as a result was protected from being the object of royal displeasure as long as he lived.⁴⁴

Needless to say, the ability to manipulate the mind and emotions of sovereigns was a double-edged sword. On the one hand, it made lettrists natural allies to ambitious up-and-comers seeking to unseat their superiors; on the other hand, it suggested them as a dangerous liability to any political players who, having achieved power, were more concerned with maintaining the status quo. Here Shaykh Bahā'ī deploys an operation attributed to Ibn Sīnā himself for the benefit of an imperially ambitious Shah 'Abbās:

If one wishes to bend the hearts of kings, sultans and rulers to one's will (*taskhīr-i qulūb-i pādshāhān u salāṭīn u ḥukkām*), such that they will not be able to contradict anything one says or bear one's absence even for a moment, and such that one rises in rank above all one's peers and is held

42 This figure would seem to be Amīr Khan or Amīr Beg 11 Mawṣillu, a former Aqqyunlu commander who joined the Qizilbash in 1507 and became one of the most important officers of the Safavid state, holding such posts as guardian of prince Ṭahmāsb and governor-general of Khurasan. See Woods, *Aqqyunlu* 12, 166, 192–193. However, as Amīr Khan died in 1522, Maḥmūd Dihdār, at the height of his career between 1569 and 1576, would presumably have been no more than an infant at the height of the amir's own career. But if there is any truth to the relationship posited here between Amīr Khan and Maḥmūd, this suggests that the latter may have been born in the last decades of the ninth/fifteenth century and lived for almost 100 years.

43 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsīmī* 85–86.

44 Ibid. 86.

in the highest esteem by sultans, one should, when the Sun is in exaltation, engrave the following number as a 6×6 magic square on a plate of gold, and *bismi Llāh bismi Llāh bismi Llāhi l-Raḥmāni l-Raḥīm* [= 1,122] at the top: 3,851.

This operation is one that Shaykh Bū 'Alī [i.e., Ibn Sīnā] took from Shaykh Yahyā 'Arab, a prominent scholar of his day, whence Mawlānā Aḥmad Lārī took it. One day this great seal talisman (*muhr*) was described to the king, [which prompted] someone present to remark that Mullā Aḥmad Lārī's books were in the possession of Allāh Virdi Khan. Someone was therefore dispatched to bring these books, and when they had arrived Shaykh Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad [al-'Āmilī] (God sanctify his secret) carried out [on their basis] just this operation to subjugate the hearts of all creatures and kings. He did so in the year 1010 after the Hijra [i.e., 1601CE] when the Sun was in exaltation, and bound [the resulting seal talisman] on the arm of the king. The first conquest [Shah 'Abbās] achieved [as a result] was his taking of Tabriz [from the Ottomans in 1603]; thenceforth his career of conquest (*jahāngīrī*) was daily furthered. [A similar seal talisman] was made for the renowned governor (*navvāb-i 'aliyya-yi 'aliya*) [Allāh Virdi Khan], who attained his exalted office thereby.⁴⁵ There is, in short, no better operation than this for the purpose of subjugation.

If one wishes to make [such a seal talisman] for other great kings, one must add to this number [that of] the holy verse *Now there has come to you a Messenger from among yourselves; grievous [to him is your suffering, anxious is he over you, and to the believers] gentle, compassionate* (Q 9:128) [= 2,782].⁴⁶ One must also, having performed a full ablution (*ghusl*), don a white robe, and during the operation hold [a piece of] sugar (*nabāt*) in one's mouth until its completion (a maneuver held to be most effective by practitioners of this art); one must also perform the ritual ablution and burn aloeswood and ambergris incense to perfume the air, thereby rendering [the operation] impressive and honorable to all.⁴⁷

45 The fact that Allāh Virdi Khan's onetime attendant and vizier of Fars, Siyāqī Nizām (d. 1603), introduced precisely a lettrist section in defense of Shah 'Abbās's imperial legitimacy in the introduction to his chronicle *Futūḥāt-i humāyūn*—in this following venerable early Timurid precedent—is highly relevant in this context; see Quinn, *Historical writing* 46–53.

46 A marginal note gives 2,898, which cannot be correct.

47 Ps.-Kāshifī, *Asrār-i Qāsimī* 88–89.

Shaykh Bahā'ī's fame as the greatest sage-mage of Safavid Iran, in sum, was no later fiction back-projected by superstitious plebes of the Qajar era wistful for lost imperial glory, but already firmly established among scholarly elites during his lifetime and immediately after. For it precisely answered the needs of contemporary Safavid intellectual-imperial culture—which explicitly embraced occultism as a primary means of Shi'izing Iran. Because he himself wrote few overtly occult-scientific works, however, modern historians, occultophobic as a rule, have facily discounted or even disappeared this central feature of his intellectual identity and sociopolitical role, emphasizing instead his brilliance in True Sciences like astronomy or law.⁴⁸ This reflexive and entrenched historiographical distortion of such early modern Muslim renaissance men as Shaykh Bahā'ī makes impossible—is indeed *designed* to make impossible—the comparative study of alternate Western early moderni-

48 Shaykh Bahā'ī's surviving oeuvre would seem to contain few authentic occult-scientific works, although several have been consistently attributed to him and indeed frequently published as such in modern editions. His popular *fālnāma*, dedicated to Shah 'Abbās, may well be authentic, and has been published at least 13 times in the last 70 years; see e.g. *Fālnāma-yi Shaykh Bahā'ī*, ed. M. 'Alī-Niyā, Tehran 1363 Sh./1984; Yādgar, 1374 Sh./1995; Gulī, 1384 Sh./2005; and Naṣrābādī, *Kitābshināsī* 640–641, no. 56. Perhaps also authentic is a manual of *jafr* sometimes entitled *Baḥr al-'ulūm al-jafrīyya* (Naṣrābādī, *Kitābshināsī* 225–226, no. 35). Various passages in his perennially popular *Kashkūl* are likewise suggestive, such as its brief discussion of *'ilm al-ṭilasmāt*, which concludes by asserting: “The science of talismans is easier to learn and deploy than the science of magic (*'ilm al-siḥr*).” Al-'Āmilī, *Kashkūl* ii, 188. The fact that Shaykh Bahā'ī there cites Ibn Turka's *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* in support of the epistemological superiority of oneness to existence is likewise highly significant. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 79.

By contrast, the Persian *al-Sirr al-mustatir dar 'ulūm-i gharība u jafr u kh'ābnāma* that is often attributed to Shaykh Bahā'ī in modern printings is rather by one Muḥammad Riẓā Saqqāzāda Vā'iz, who compiled it as an anthology of material on the various occult sciences (see [Tehran 1964?]); the Arabic print version has been published at least thrice: Qom 2005, Beirut 2005, and Qom 1427/2006. See Naṣrābādī, *Kitābshināsī* 628–629, no. 40. Further works whose authenticity Naṣrābādī doubts include the Arabic treatise *Aḥkām al-naẓar fī katf al-shāh*, on scapulomancy (ibid. 610, no. 4); the Arabic treatise *Istikhāra bā Qur'ān*, on two methods of quranic bibliomancy taken from Ibn Ṭāwūs (ibid. 611, no. 7); and *Ijāz-i asmā' Allāh ta'ālā*, a short Persian treatise on the inimitability and effects of the divine names, written by the author for his son Muḥammad Amīn (ibid. 612, no. 9; it has been published as *Kashf-i rumūz-i ism-i a'ẓam*). (As he notes, Āqā Buzurg proposes as author of the last work Shaykh Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad al-Makkī al-'Āmilī, Bahā' al-Dīn Muḥammad b. Muḥsin al-'Āmilī, or Muḥammad b. Muḥsin al-'Āmilī.) MS Malik 618, a substantial (238 ff.) Arabic lettrist work on the active properties of divine names copied in the fourteenth/twentieth century, is presumably the same treatise. For her part, 'Abbās rejects the authenticity of all such works, dismissing them—rather rashly, as this study suggests—as being flatly “incompatible with Shaykh Bahā'ī's approach and intellectual style.” 'Abbās, *Bahā' al-Dīn al-'Āmilī* 267, 286.

ties: only European Renaissance men are currently historiographically free to be the committed occult scientists they so frequently were.⁴⁹

To remedy such a massive imbalance in the literature on our Safavid sage-mage, thus making comparative study possible, I propose the oeuvre of his lettrist teacher as key to this crucial aspect of his scholarly and political identity: all the occultist operations with which Shaykh Bahā'ī is credited are there laid out in exhaustive scientific detail. Due to persistent scholarly occultophobia, however, Dihdār's many works on lettrism remain entirely unpublished; while certain of them do circulate rather widely online, they do so only in (usually poorly) scanned lithograph or manuscript form. His magnum opus, the definitive manual *Mafātīḥ al-maghālīq* (Keys to all locks), would seem to be particularly popular—a Google search on this title, unique to Dihdār, returns over 56,000 hits.⁵⁰ A huge amount of basic philological spadework thus lies before us; of the major lacunae that riddle our knowledge of Islamicate early modernity, none yawns wider or is more debilitating than the almost total absence of studies on the occult sciences and reliable editions of even the most seminal occult-scientific texts.

Let us, then, to the texts. The historiographical benefits that will accrue from such a philological renaissance are hinted at by the example of several recent editions of Safavid texts that, while not exclusively occult-scientific in focus, contain substantial material in that vein. I cited above Mīr Dāmād's *Jazavāt u mavāqīt* and *Nibrās al-dīyā'*, both featuring lettrist content, as well as Kāzīrūnī's *Sullam al-samāwāt*. (Rustamdārī's landmark *Riyāz al-abrār*, naturally, has yet to be published.) While such works shed much-needed light on Shaykh Bahā'ī's immediate intellectual and social context, a fourth recently published text is perhaps even more telling: Quṭb al-Dīn Ishkavarī Lāhījī's (d. btw. 1677 and 1684) *Latāyif al-ḥisāb* (Subtleties of calculation).⁵¹ This manual of mathematics, penned by the Safavid *shaykh al-islām* of Lahijan and protégé of Mīr Dāmād and Shaykh Bahā'ī both, complements the latter's far more popular *Khulāṣat al-ḥisāb*, used as a textbook for centuries after.⁵² But unlike that work, which has no occult-scientific content, Ishkavarī's features an appendix that explicitly presents lettrism as the discipline's *most immediate application*, especially for scholars of a Twelver persuasion: the introduction holds up 'Alī as mathe-

49 I call for such a comparative study, a new philological revolution, in Melvin-Koushki, *Tahqīq* vs. *taqlīd*; see also Melvin-Koushki, (De)colonizing early modern occult philosophy.

50 This as of August 2017.

51 Ishkavarī, *Latāyif al-ḥisāb*.

52 For a discussion of this seminal textbook see 'Abbās, *Bahā' al-Dīn al-Āmilī* 645–668.

mathematical exemplar, and the *khātima* opens with a lettrist analysis of the names of Muḥammad and the Twelve Imams (all being ontologically intrinsic to Q 33:33), treats of finger counting (*‘uqūd-i aṣābi’*) and fraction of numeration (*taksīr*), then closes with a long section on logogriphs (sg. *mu‘ammā*) and riddles (sg. *lughz*) and their solutions, which prominently features Shaykh Bahā’ī as master of this art—a mainstay of lettrist practice from Ibn Turka onward.⁵³

Ishkavarī’s manual, like those of Dihdār, thus makes explicit a social rule Shaykh Bahā’ī’s oeuvre leaves largely implicit: *to be a Safavid mathematician is to be a lettrist, and to be a lettrist is to magically protect and shape empire*. Such a conclusion can only further strengthen the emerging scholarly consensus that the epochal transposition of Safavid Iran to a hierocratic Twelver footing was accomplished less by state policy than by popular, saintly, charismatic, and syncretizing scholars like Shaykh Bahā’ī, primary architects and engineers, in every sense of those job titles, of the new Safavid Shi’i imperial culture.⁵⁴ Safavidists in particular, of course, have long contended with the question of saintly charisma and its historically transformative routinizations; but they must now account for the *scientific method* many prominent Safavid scholars successfully followed in its pursuit.

3 Pseudo-Shaykh Bahā’ī on the Supreme Name

That scientific method so rigorously on display in Dihdār’s authentic oeuvre is far less so in the popular lettrist poem attributed to his greatest student; indeed, it is there downgraded, as it were, to mere “pop science.” I noted above, however, that pseudo-Shaykh Bahā’ī’s *maṣnavī* on the Supreme Name is nevertheless at core authentic: over half of its 104 lines are taken from Dihdār’s *Kunūz al-asmā’*, a 383-line didactic poem on lettrist methods of deriving various divine names for magical and divinatory purposes, and the focus of *Javāhir al-asrār*, Dihdār’s autocommentary on this work, which reproduces the poem in its entirety.

53 Ishkavarī, *Laṭāyif al-hisāb* 12–13, 67–70, and 74–92 respectively; and Melvin-Koushki, *Quest* 382–385; Binbaş, *Intellectual networks* 84–85. My thanks to Mathieu Terrier for this reference.

54 See Anzali, “Mysticism” in *Iran*; Moin, ‘*Ulama*’ as ritual specialists; Melvin-Koushki, *Occult science of empire*; on Shaykh Bahā’ī as legal architect of the same see Abisaab, New ropes for royal tents. Significantly, it would seem that the architects of the Islamic Republic in Iran have returned to this ideal, consciously or otherwise; Imam Khomeini himself referred to the “Islamic republic system” (*nizām-i jumhūrī-yi islāmī*) as an expression of “divine geometry” (*handasa-yi ilāhī*). Tavakoli-Targhi, Clerico-engineering.

At the same time, the anonymous reworker of Dihdār's original did not simply take lines at random, but was clearly at pains to obscure the original import of those lines, whether by changing their wording at key junctures or by changing their order in the poem and supplying many new lines, from an as yet unknown source or authored for the purpose, to disrupt their logical flow. (Of the *maṣnavī*'s 104 lines, a full 45 are thus added.) Where the *Kunūz al-asmā'* treats of a range of lettrist techniques as applied to various divine names, that is, the reworked version treats solely of a single Name, the *ism-i a'ẓam*, which is yet identified only very cryptically—and using lines that have very different referents in the original. Since its reworking, moreover, many corruptions have further muddled the text, due precisely to its popularity, and the various latter-day versions circulating widely in print and online are frequently divergent, and equally frequently nonsensical and nonmetrical.

In other words: both by design and through textual corruption over time, the lettrist operations alluded to in the poem below are *scientifically invalid*, and hence do not admit of serious analysis. The value of this text rather lies primarily in its status as a popular vehicle for later imaginaries of high Safavid imperial-intellectual culture. I therefore see little need to follow Ayatollah Ḥasan Ḥasanzāda Āmulī's procedure in his 1979 commentary on the poem, *R. Rumūz-i kunūz* (On the allusions in [Dihdār's] *Kunūz*), wherein he does attempt to decipher these terminally cryptic allusions. Sayyid Muḥammad Ḥasan Mīr-Jahānī Ṭabāṭabā'ī (d. 1992) attempts the same in his own, though much briefer, commentary.⁵⁵ Both scholars recognize the highly corrupt nature of the text, and correctly associate it with Dihdār; Ḥasanzāda Āmulī goes further to establish a more reliable version of the text with reference to his personal manuscript copy of Dihdār's *Javāhir al-asrār*.⁵⁶

To make more historiographically usable this unique window onto Safavid high lettrist culture at the turn of the eleventh/seventeenth century, as well as its afterlives to the present, I therefore provide a “corrected” edition, with modernized transcription, on the basis of manuscript copies of Dihdār's original. In this I do follow Ḥasanzāda Āmulī, although my reading diverges from his in a number of places, due in part to the different manuscripts of the *Javāhir al-asrār* I have at my disposal; I also note certain reasonable variations in the

55 Mīr-Jahānī, *Ravāyih al-nasamāt* 100–113.

56 He also references Dihdār's magnum opus, *Mafātih-i maghālīq*, throughout his commentary, as well as other seminal Safavid-era occult-scientific manuals, including Sayyid 'Abdallāh Balyānī's (fl. 1576) *Jahān al-raml* (World of geomancy); see Melvin-Koushki, Persianate geomancy.

footnotes, but ignore nonsensical corruptions. What minimal commentary I provide in the footnotes largely depends on his and Mīr-Jahānī's. I must stress, however, that no edition of the reworked poem can be definitive; that offered here simply seeks to approximate what it may have looked like at inception, when each line, however divergent from its source, presumably still made a measure of sense.

As for provenance: my tentative dating of this odd little text to the Qajar period (1779–1925) is likewise purely impressionistic; much further research into Qajar scholarly culture in general and its receptions of Shaykh Bahā'ī and Maḥmūd Dihdār in particular will be necessary to strengthen, deny, or confirm it. But there does exist, at least, a *terminus ante quem*: 1258 (1842), the copying date of a *majmū'a* that contains what appears to be a rather heavily abridged version of the same, with emphasis on the non-original section on the name Jochebed (*ramz-i nām-i mādar-i Mūsā*), but including Dihdār's original lines as well, under the *takhalluṣ* Bahā'ī.⁵⁷ That this version is focused on this name rather than the Supreme Name indicates that the poem, while already recognizable, was still textually very much in flux during the first half of the thirteenth/nineteenth century; this fact alone strongly suggests it to be a Qajar product.

In its various versions, moreover, sensical or otherwise, the poem is patently an exercise in cultural remembrance. What little scientific content has been retained from the original, then haphazardly recombined, is evidently deployed solely for symbolic purposes—the reworker was certainly no letrist adept. That is, the text rather smacks of the *neoclassicizing* ethos of the Qajar period, which saw a profusion of similar pseudepigrapha in all fields, from philosophy to poetry;⁵⁸ it also reflects the contemporary uptick in occultist prognostication ahead of the millennium of the Imam's occultation (1874 CE).⁵⁹

57 MS Majlis 1149/5, fols. 56b–57a. I did not have access to this *majmū'a* at the time of writing, but the Majlis catalog description, which includes a partial transcription, suggests that this version of the *maṣnavī* opens with line 9, moves directly to line 18, the beginning of the section on Jochebed, and ends much as the longer version does.

58 My thanks to Sajjad Rizvi for this observation; see e.g. Rizvi, *Hikma muta'aliya*; Rizvi, Shi'i political theology. This neoclassicizing impulse is epitomized by the twelfth/eighteenth-century *bāzgasht-i adabī* (literary return), an initially partial and decidedly local movement whose victory over “decadent” early modern Newspeak (*tāza-gū'ī*) was totalized in the late thirteenth/nineteenth and early fourteenth/twentieth centuries in colonialist-nationalist discourse. On the early modern tension between *perennialist progressivism*—espoused precisely by Safavid scholars like Shaykh Bahā'ī, Mīr Dāmād, and Maḥmūd Dihdār—and *declinist neoclassicism*, see Melvin-Koushki, *Tahqiq vs. taqlīd*.

59 Rizvi, Shi'i political theology 698.

It must further be emphasized that the Shaykhi and Babi movements both embraced precisely lettrism in furtherance of their respective millenarian projects.⁶⁰ The lionization of Shaykh Bahā'ī specifically as preeminent Safavid mage, while rooted in indisputable historical and textual reality, thus accords particularly well with broader Qajar cultural tendencies, and the poem's disregard for scientific detail accords poorly with Safavid. As Tunikābunī's *Tales of the scholars* testifies most eloquently, patently legendary material had accreted to the persona of Safavid luminaries like Shaykh Bahā'ī by the mid-thirteenth/nineteenth century. Our text, romantically and unusably cryptic, accordingly points vaguely—though in this case quite rightly—to lettrism as the source of its hero's powers.

This is not to suggest that some Qajar scholars would have been unaware of the simultaneous bogusness and appropriateness of the poem's attribution to Shaykh Bahā'ī. The circle of Mullā 'Alī Nūrī here again deserves special mention: a philosophical neoclassicist, Nūrī was clearly cognizant of and much exercised by the lettrist writings of Mīr Dāmād and Ibn Turka both—the theory behind Dihdār's praxis. It is thus no surprise that one of his students, Mullā Muḥammad Ja'far Lāhijī (d. 1844), wrote one of his handful of works as an *'irfānī* commentary on another lettrist poem, wholly authentic, by Dihdār, dedicating it to the powerful Qajar governor Mu'tamad al-Dawla Manūchihr Khan Gurjī (d. 1847).⁶¹ Likewise, most of the manuscript copies of Dihdār's *Javāhir al-asrār* date to the Qajar period.

While not conclusive, such elite Qajar scholarly investment in Safavid intellectual culture thus suggests our text to be a product of a more popular, if still scholarly, milieu. As that may be, its rise in popularity would not seem to predate the early thirteenth/nineteenth century; and the commentaries thereon by such outstanding modern Iranian Twelver scholars as Sayyid Mīr-Jahānī Ṭabāṭabā'ī and Ayatollah Ḥasanzāda Āmulī testify to the remarkably durable salience to the present of this Safavid-Qajar lettrist classic.

4 Note on the Text

Maḥmūd Dihdār's *Javāhir al-asrār* is preserved in Iran in some 23 manuscript copies (one partial), of which I currently have access to three, all Qajar-era;⁶²

60 Cole, *World as text*; Melvin-Koushki, *Quest* 281.

61 Lāhijī, *Sharḥ-i abyāt-i Dihdār*.

62 MS Majlis 12653/1, fols. 1b–68a (copied 1231/1816); MS Majlis 12890/13, pp. 155–162 (19th c.); MS Milli 18796/1, fols. 2a–73b (n.d.).

these preserve the full text of the author's didactic lettrist poem *Kunūz al-asmā'*, interspersed with prose commentary. As for the reworked poem attributed to Shaykh Bahā'ī that is the subject of this study, of the many versions circulating in print and online I have relied in the main on those given in Javāhirī's 1993 edition of Shaykh Bahā'ī's *Kullīyyāt*,⁶³ Mīr-Jahānī's 1954 commentary,⁶⁴ and Ḥujjat Balāghī's 1971 compilation *Ya'sūb: Az har chaman gulī*,⁶⁵ but I have usually preferred Ḥasanzāda Āmulī's 1979 version, corrected with reference to the author's personal manuscript copy of the *Javāhir al-asrār*.⁶⁶ To highlight the authentic core of the poem, those lines not original to Dihdār have been bracketed in the translation.⁶⁷ Finally, again following Ḥasanzāda Āmulī, I have replaced throughout the three instances of Bahā'ī's *takhalluṣ* with Dihdār's: 'Iyānī, "Eyewitness."⁶⁸

5 Text and Translation

A! O you at whose command the two worlds are perfected: ۱ ای دو عالم به یک امر از تو تمام
all beings from you are strung together and ordered!⁶⁹ ۲ کاینات از تو به تنسيق و نظام
Whatever arises from these planes nine, هر چه بر جاست در این تسعه بساط

63 *Kullīyyāt* 93–99.

64 *Ravāyih al-nasamāt* 101–113.

65 *Ya'sūb* 2–8. Significantly, Balāghī attributes the poem to both Shaykh Bahā'ī and Maḥmūd Dihdār.

66 *Rumūz-i Kunūz*.

67 See also the unpublished but helpful draft translation by Stephen Lambden, which I discovered only after my own was complete; it is overliteral, however, and depends solely on Javāhirī's corrupt version: <http://hurqalya.ucmerced.edu/sites/hurqalya.ucmerced.edu/files/page/documents/rumuz.pdf> (accessed 7 June 2017).

68 As Dihdār declares in his *Javāmi' al-favā'id* (Tehran, MS Millī 18712 p. 33): "I have opened the door for you / and further explained my cryptic words: // thus is my penname Eyewitness ('Iyānī) / for in such wise do I find you an Entic Well (*ki dar īn shīva 'ayn-i'yān-am*)." (He here plays on the word series *'ayn-i'yān-i'yān*, the first meaning "eye," "spring" and "essence," the second "eyewitnessing" and the third "finding a spring or well.") Similarly, in his *Ḥall al-rumūz fī sharḥ al-kunūz* (MS Millī 7706/1, p. 412): "I have thoroughly explicated these cryptic statements, / have broken the talisman guarding the secret treasure—// hence have I been given the penname Eyewitness / and the overflowing knowledge of such arcana."

69 My translation here incorporates Ḥasanzāda Āmulī's reading of the vocative particle *ay* as a pregnant lettrist allusion to the preeternal nature of the *alif*. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 373.

whatever appears from these lodges seven ⁷⁰ —	و آنچه پیداست در این هفت رباط	
all have their being from your bounty	همه از جود تو دارند وجود	3
and do bow and prostrate before your way;	پیش راهت به رکوعند و سجود	
for from our being from yours do we inhabit the traces,	چون به هستی ز تو در آئاریم	4
our eyes fixed upon your encompassing grace.	چشم بر لطف عمیمت داریم	
The <i>letter</i> , to the wise and perceptive,	نزد اهل خرد و اهل عیان	5
is a body whose spirit is its <i>number</i> .	حرف جسم و عدد اوست چه جان	
Had not the letters their numerical values	یعنی اعداد حروف ارنود	6
prayers could never be answered.	سرّ دعوات مقرر نشود	
The effect of a Name, whatever it be,	اثر اسم به هر اندازه	7
and however invoked,	که بخوانند به هر آوازه	
is such that any prayer must be answered	هیچ شک نیست که در اسرع حال	8
immediately and exactly: of this there is no doubt.	به اجابت برسد بی اهمال	
And the letter is the imperial treasurehouse and jewelhoard	گنج اسمای الهی ⁷¹ حرف است	9
wherein God's Names are kept.	گوهر مخزن شاهی حرف است	
<i>Thirty and six</i> letters are they as spoken and heard; ⁷²	سی و شش حرف که در گفت و شنید	10
but their intimations are endless,	کس به پایان رموزش نرسید	
their range of effects eternally infinite:	اثرش نامتناهی به دوام	11
whether noble or common, all do benefit.	منتفع زو چه خواص و چه عوام	
They explicate the rarefied realm of high heaven	شارح عالم خاص جبروت	12
and open heaven and earth to conquest;	فاتح عالم ملک و ملکوت	

⁷⁰ I.e., the nine celestial spheres and seven terrestrial climes.

⁷¹ The original here has rather *asrār-i ilāhī*.

⁷² The next line in Dihdār's original explains this with reference to the gematrical value (*hisāb-i jummal*) of the Name *ilāh* (36); but what the seven letters added to the 29 of the Arabic alphabet (28 and *lām-alif*) could be is not otherwise clear—perhaps the planets? Cf. Ḥasanzāda Āmulī's review of alternative alphabetical tallies. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 384–388.

they summon divinity's very secret,	سرّ لاهوت از آن در حضر است	13
and enlighten humanity's soul.	جان ناسوت از آن باخبر است	
They are the origin of every atom,	نطق هر ذره از آن در قال است	14
as tradition tells us, and all mystics confirm; ⁷³	داند این هر که ز اهل حال است	
many are their effects in this earthly realm,	بس اثرهاست در این عالم خاک	15
as the spiritually alive are aware—	که کنند اهل معانی ادراک	
for naught of all that appears in this two-pathed cloister	هر چه پیدا است در این دیر دو راه	16
does so but it manifests God's Names.	نیست بی جلوه اسماء اله	
[Yet the Supreme Name is hidden from view,	اسم اعظم که نهان از نظر است	17
and no intellect can attain it.	عقلها جمله از آن بی خبر است ⁷⁴	
The Just has Names a thousand and one,	الف و یک اسم که دارد دادار	18
each with a special benefit when activated. ⁷⁵	هر یکی فایده ای را در کار	
One of them was known to a certain prophet—	یک از آن داشت یکی پیغمبر	19
Moses's mother's father, a nomad;	پدر مادر موسی ازیر	
but he kept it hidden from all,	لیک می داشت نهان از هر کس	20
and was content to simply be father of [Amram],	پدرش بود در این عالم و بس	
who, by command of the Lord of the world,	تا به فرمان خداوند جهان	21
was ennobled with its knowledge in turn.	یافت عمران شرف وصلت آن	
Having learned of this holy Name—	شد از آن اسم مقدّس آگاه	22
supreme among God's Names—	که بود اعظم اسماء الله	

73 Needless to say, to translate *ahl-i ḥāl* (usually, as here, contrasted with *ahl-i qāl*) as “mystics” is extremely problematic; I do so here only for reasons of style, as there is no proper term in English for “the folk of immediate experience.”

74 Lines 17–30 are not in Dihdār's original.

75 Ḥasanẓāda Āmulī cites in support of this more unusual number (i.e., than the tropic 99) two verses from the opening section (on *tawḥīd*) of Sanāʾī's (d. 1131) *Ḥadiqat al-ḥaqāʾiq*, as well as the 1,001 divine names included in the Greater Armor (*al-jawshan al-kabīr*) sup-
plication ascribed to the fourth Twelver Imam, Zayn al-ʿĀbidīn ʿAlī. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii,

- He prayed: "O Lord, by the virtues of this Name,
by the utter sanctity of this Name,
grant me a noble son
possessed of wisdom, knowledge and authority!
Make him one of Your prophets
and console him at every turn;
and grant him a son, O glorious Lord,
who shall cast Pharaoh's robe into the Nile."
Noah likewise was saved from perishing in the Flood
solely through the blessing of this Name and its virtues.
Thus too did Moses speak with the divine manifestation
as fire on the mount.
When Jesus invoked this name,
the dead were raised by its power.
All that is in the world subsists through this Name:
hence its status as the treasury of all Names].⁷⁶
It is a pearl from the oystershell of mysteries,
a matchless royal jewel.
Oh, what a Name is this,
far beyond the ken of most!⁷⁷
Its properties are infinite;
it irradiates its knowers.
- 23 گفت یارب به صفات این اسم
به حق حرمت ذات این اسم
24 که مرا ده ولدی با مقدار
صاحب معرفت و علم و وقار
25 نبی مرسل خود ساز او را
در همه باب تو بنواز او را
26 داد او را پسری ربّ جلیل
که زد او جامه فرعون به نیل
27 نوح از برکت این اسم و صفات
یافت از مملکت آب نجات
28 موسی از برکت این اسم به طور
یافت گفتار تجلّی با نور
29 عیسی این اسم چو برخواند اموات
یافتند از اثر اسم حیات
30 هر چه در عالم از این اسم به پاست
زان که این اسم کنوز الاسماست
31 که این درّ از صدف اسرار است
بی بدل چون گهر شہوار است
32 وه چه اسم است که بسیار کسی
نیستش بر سرّ آن دسترسی
33 خاصّیتهاش ندارد پایان
عارفان نیز بدان در تابان⁷⁸

293. See Mullā Hādī Sabzavārī's (d. 1873) often lettrist commentary on the same, *Sharḥ al-asmā'*.

76 i.e., the *kunūz al-asmā'*—a reference to the title of Dihdār's original poem.

77 This line in the original refers rather to the method of *taksīr*.

78 In the original: ندارد پایان | عارفانند به آن دانیان

- Worldly fortunes, whether good or bad,
may be derived in general guise [from that Name].
It is a special Name indeed—for in its letters
are safely hidden all the secrets of the cosmos,
which are known only
to those chief among the righteous.
If you utter this Name repeatedly,
activating it according to mathematical usage,
you will achieve your desire in every affair
and revel in perpetual divine grace.
[This Name confers 14 benefits in particular.⁸²
First, it enables you to break talismans.
It makes your enemies run like mercury
and enslaves them with its floodlike assault.
If you invoke it sincerely and with certitude,
you will find buried treasure.
Jinn will be your companions,
all saints will associate with you,
all people will defer to you—
even the caesar of Rome will become your slave.
- 34 وضع آفاق⁷⁹ ز نیک و بد حال
می توان یافت به سنج اجمال⁸⁰
35 اسم خاصی است که اسرار جهان
هست در کنز حروفش پنهان
36 کس چه داند که چه اسرار است این
خاصه زمره ابرار است این
37 لفظ این اسم چو تکرار کنی
چون به آداب عدد کار کنی
38 قفل هر کار گشایی به مراد
گردی از فیض مداما دلشاد⁸¹
39 چارده نفع رساند آن اسم
اولین آن که گشایی تو طلسم⁸³
40 دشمنت نیست شود چون سیلاب
بند گردد به دمیدن سیلاب
41 گرجخوانی ز سر صدق و یقین
کشف گردد همه گنج زمین
42 جینان با تو مصاحب گردند
اولیا جمله به تو پیوندند
43 جمله خلق سرافکنده تو
قیصر روم شود بنده تو

79 Ḥasanẓāda Āmulī suggests *awfāq* as a preferable reading. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 402.

80 The original referent here is a comprehensive prognosticon (*jafr-i jāmi'*), significantly styled a cosmic *zīj*: گنجی جامع چه اگر مشهور است | سر آن لیک بسی مستور است || آن گنجی است که احوال جهان | هست در کسر حروفش پنهان || زیچ دوران است که نیک و بد حال | ز آن توان یافت به هیچ اجمال || کسی چه داند که چه اسرار است آن | خاصه زمره ابرار است آن

81 Lines 37–38 in the original: لفظ هر اسم که تکرار کنی | چون به آداب عدد کار کنی || قفل هر باب گشایی به مراد | گردی از فیض قرأت استاد

82 A full 14 benefits do not follow in this or other printed versions at my disposal.

83 Lines 39–47 are not in Dihdār's original.

You will be beloved of all.	44	همه خلق حبیب گردد
You will also attain alchemy,		کیمیا نیز نصیب گردد
and easily master every difficult science.	45	هیچ علمی به تو مشکل نشود
Not for an instant will the Real forget you.		یک زمان حق ز تو غافل نشود
You will be forever smiling and joyous	46	متصل با لب خندان دلشاد
and your worldly and spiritual affairs prosper alike.		دین و دنیای تو گردد آباد
Yet each person's path to knowing	47	لیک هر کس به طریقی دیگر
this Name's potency is different.]		دارد از حالت این اسم خبر
The secret of all Names is wholly comprised by its letters.	48	سرّ اسماء حروفش به تمام
But never disclose this to the public:		توان گفت مبدا که عوام ⁸⁴
for having learned of it, they will attempt to use it	49	مطلع گشته به آن کار کنند
and harm many people in their ignorance.		خلق را بیده آزار کنند
The cryptic teachings of the elite must never be elucidated	50	رمز خاصان توان گفت تمام
lest ignorant fools learn how to act on them;		تا نیابد اثرش جاهل خام
such are they who deviate from the path of justice	51	زوروند از پی انصاف به در ⁸⁵
and are unwary of evils.		وز بدی ها ننمایند حذر
[It is permitted only to mature individuals,	52	باشد از حسن عمل اهل کمال
who will act only worthily with the power of this Name,		چون بیابند از این اسم مجال ⁸⁶
and never intend evil thereby,	53	در عمل عزم بدی ها نکنند
nor think of any unlawful thing.		فکر در باب ردی ها نکنند
In the Torah, God called [Amram's wife] Jochebed,	54	یوخابد خوانده خدا در تورات
in other scriptures He called her Nakhvāt, ⁸⁷		در صحف خوانده خدایش عورات ⁸⁸

84 The line's original referent is again *taksīr*: توان گفت مبدا که عوام

85 This first hemistich repeats the second of line 78 below.

86 Lines 52–62 are not in the original.

87 I here prefer the alternative reading, although have not found evidence for *Nakhvāt* as a known alternative; *Yārkhā*/*Yāwkhā* and *Yārkhāt* are sometimes given, however, so *Nakhvāt*—perhaps *Yakhvāt*—could be a corruption of the latter.

88 Alternatively: یوخابد گفت حق اندر تورات | در صحف گفته خدایش نخواست

- and in the sura that is the Gospels called [‘Imrān’s wife] 55 حنه در سورة انجيل بخوان
- Hannah: all are perfectly correct.⁸⁹ 56 به درستی که همان است همان⁹⁰
- In our own Quran there occurs [the same name] 57 هست در مصحف ما بعد سه میم
- after the three Ms in the midmost sura among the *ḥāwāmīm* در میان سوری از حامیم
- whose *bayyina* equals 70:⁹¹ 57 مخرج یبینه اش هفتاد است
- this is a master principle [to follow]. این همه قاعده استاد است
- For where one person [calls Jochebed] Ṭaysūm, 58 خوانده طیسوم دگریک قیسوم
- another says Qaysūm, and a Maghribi Hayshūm,⁹² مغربی گفته به لفظ هیشوم
- while among the Arabs Jochebed (*Yūkhābad*) is standard— 59 هست مشهور عرب یوخابد
- but a Persian says Barkhānad! عجمی گفته و را برخاند
- [Likewise,] a Daylami will write *kāfilnā* 60 دیلی کرده رقم کافلنا
- but another group *rāḥilnā*.⁹³ باز جمع دگرش راحلنا
- Yet another group offers *jāmarruth* 61 تحیه قوم دگرش جامرث
- where a fourth prefers *gāmarruth*.⁹⁴ هست یوخابه دگر گامرث
- [In short:] in recording and retelling names 62 در احادیث و روایات و خبر
- everyone has their own version.] هریکی را است طریقی دیگر

89 In reference to Q 3:33–35, some Quran commentators draw an equivalence between Amram and Jochebed, parents of Moses, and ‘Imrān and Hannah, parents of Mary; similarly, an ontological equivalence is apparently being drawn here between the mother of Moses and the mother of Mary despite their differing names.

90 Javāhirī gives lines 55–61 as follows: حنه در سورة انجيل بخوان | بحقیقت که هم اینست وهم آن || خوانده طیوم دیگر یک قیوم | مغربی گفت که هست او هیوم || هست مشهور عرب بر جانه | عجمی گفت و را برخانه || دیلی کرد رقم کافلنا | باز جمعی دگرش راحلنا || نجیه قوم دگر جاهر شا | هست بوخانه دگر طاهر شا

91 Ḥasanzāda Āmulī notes that the Name here in question is ‘*alīm*, All-knowing, and cites its uses in invocation. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 407–409.

92 Cf. Mudarris, *Rayḥānat al-adab* vii, 26, who lists the variants of the name Jochebed (Yūch-ābadh, Abādkhā, Abādkhat), then cites Ibn al-Athīr’s further variants: “It is said that the name of Moses’s mother—by which all locks and bindings may [magically] be opened—is as follows: Ṭaysūm, Ayūm, Qayūm, Daymūm, Dayūm.”

93 I.e., “we contracted” and “we equipped for a journey” respectively.

94 This line is particularly corrupt—perhaps these are meant to be two further versions of Jochebed?

But for all that this Name is extremely famous,	63	گرچه این اسم بسی مشهور است
here I have something else in view. ⁹⁵		لیک اینجا نه چنین منظور است
[My years now being one hundred ten,	64	سال عمرم به صد و ده چو رسید
I have therefore thought to rend this secret's veil]		فکرتم پرده از این راز درید ⁹⁶
and so have brought forth the priceless provision	65	از ذخایر که کنوز الاسماست
that is the treasures of the Names, ⁹⁷		بنده این گنج برآوردم راست ⁹⁸
and have carried out this task in all propriety	66	بهر آسانی ارباب طلب
to ease the way for serious seekers,		کردم این کار به آداب و ادب
to put a spring in their step, so they may attain	67	خواستم تا که در این علم به کام
of this science what they desire—such was my aim.		بنهم بر قدم مردان گام
God the One be praised, Who in this art	68	لله الحمد که توفیق احد
has granted me the effluxion of His aid!		داد در این هنرم فیض مدد
So mightily have I striven in this science	69	من در این علم بسی بردم رنج
as to break all [treasury] talismans with this treasure, ⁹⁹		که طلسمات گشودم ز این گنج
and have now opened it	70	سر این گنج گهر بگشودم
and brought out its jewels for inspection,		گوهر گنج عیان بنمودم
and paraded its hours entirely veiless	71	حوریان راهمه بی ستر و نقاب
for the benefit of my friends. ¹⁰⁰		بنمودم به تمام احباب
I have opened the treasury to seekers	72	بهر طلاب گشودم سر گنج
and freely given away its riches,		نقد این گنج نمودم بی رنج

95 The original referent here is *ḥisāb-i jummal*: همان | لیک اینجا نه همان | جمل حرف چه گر مشهور است | لیک اینجا نه همان منظور است

96 This line is not in the original. The versions of Javāhirī and Mīr-Jahānī both give the author's age as 71; in other printed versions the first hemistich reads: سال عمرم چو به آخر | رسید

97 *Kunūz al-asmā'*, again a reference to Dihdār's original.

98 In the original: از ذخایر که کنوز الاسماست | این عددها بدرآوردم راست

99 I.e., the protective talismans on treasury doors.

100 The line's original referent is the 14 light letters, i.e., the quranic *muqatta'āt*.

- have brought forth jewels from the mine of work
and removed their covering.
The wage of those who work such a special mine
is [to give] the jewels they find to the few deserving.
Because he's undertaken such charitable work
remember 'Iyāni in prayer!
In short, weariness can never turn aside
serious seekers from their purpose.
When they have mastered these principles entirely
let them recite a Fātiḥa for me,
and when they achieve results from this Name
let them not deviate from the straight path.
You who possess the secret of this science and its praxis—
that the difficulty of this science be made easy for you,
open your soul's ears and your heart's eyes
so I may do precisely that.
If you find my discourse attractive,
listen well: for the time to discourse has arrived.
If you make my words your heart's treasure
you will reap wisdom's reward.
If you seek from 'Alī's science a lesson
by way of blessing¹⁰¹
[know that] of those who have searched that vast ocean
the perfected have found many great pearls.
- 73 گوهر از کان عمل بنودم
پرده از چهره آن بگشودم
74 مزد مردی که از این معدن خاص
گوهرش را چو بیابد به خواص
75 عمل خیر چو بنیاد کند
از عیانی به دعایاد کند
76 غرض این است که ارباب طلب
نکشند از پی مقصود تعب
77 این قواعد چو سراسر دانند
بهر ما فاتحه ای برخوانند
78 چون از این اسم بیابند اثر
نروند از ره انصاف به در
79 ای که داری سرّ این علم و عمل
تا شود مشکل این علمت حلّ
80 گوش جان باز کن و دیده دل
تا کنم بهر تو حلّ این مشکل
81 گرتو را میل به تقریر من است
برگشا گوش که وقت سخن است
82 سخنم گوهر گوش دل کن
گوهر گوش خرد حاصل کن
83 اگر از علم ولی الهی
به تین سبقی می خواهی
84 بهر طلاب از آن لجّه ژرف
کاملان راست درّی چند شگرف

101 Lettrism is particularly associated with 'Alī and Ja'far by Sunni and Shi'i lettrists alike; see Melvin-Koushki, Quest 171 and *passim*.

- I myself have taken a lesson from these 85 من از آن طایفه دارم سبقی
and recite it again for them in these pages. خوانده ام در برایشان ورقی
- [These my cryptic words that make manifest my thought 86 در رموزات که فکرم جلی است
are among the gifts of Muḥammad and 'Alī.] از عطاهاى نبی و ولی است¹⁰²
- Know you not that the [Supreme] Name 87 اسم او با سور قرآنی
is [in value] equivalent to the suras of the Quran?¹⁰³ متساوی است اگر می دانی¹⁰⁴
- [Properly arranged, its letters are eight, 88 هشت حرف است به ترتیب و نظام
and expanded (*bast*) become 40 in total.¹⁰⁵ بسط حرفیش چهل گشته تمام
- As uttered its gematrical value is 19:¹⁰⁶ 89 لفظیش نوزده از روی جمل
this basic point makes possible its operation.¹⁰⁷ هست چون مدخل باسط به عمل
- Its first letter is *M*, its fourth *L*, 90 اولش میم و چهارم لام است
its third currently well known,¹⁰⁸ سیمش شهره در این ایام است
and its last letter is *T*, which has letters six— 91 ط¹¹⁰ بود آخر و شش حرف در او
understand a point comprehensible only to the pure.¹⁰⁹ نکته فهمی که بفهمد نیکو

102 With the exception of line 87, lines 86–96 are not in the original.

103 Scil., 114—a value equivalent to the Name *jāmi'*, All-comprehensive, likewise used to describe the Quran itself as a Supreme Name, as well as *jafr* (i.e., Imam 'Alī's *al-Jafr wa-l-jāmi'a*); see Ḥasanzāda Āmulī, *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 413. An alternative calculation is proposed in Mīr-Jahānī, *Ravāyih al-nasamāt* 106–107.

104 In the original: این عدد با سور قرآنی | متساوی است اگر می دانی

105 As Ḥasanzāda Āmulī notes, the Name *jāmi'* fits this description; when subjected to *bast*, it produces 8 letters (*JYMALFN*), when then subjected to *ṣadr u mu'akhhkar* over 5 lines become 40 letters in total. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 413–414. Two basic lettrist techniques, *bast* refers to the expansion of a name or word with the full name of each of its letters, while *ṣadr u mu'akhhkar* refers to the reordering of letters in a line by alternately taking letters from the beginning and end of that line, e.g. *ALFMYBNW* → *AWLNFMBY*.

106 See Ḥasanzāda Āmulī for a range of possible interpretations. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 415.

107 The line's original referent is the 19 letters of the *basmala*.

108 Ḥasanzāda Āmulī notes that four Names matching this description occur in the the thirteenth section of the *Greater Armor* (*mudīl*, *munīl*, *muqīl*, *muḥīl*), and ten in the forty-ninth (*musahhīl*, *mufaḍḍīl*, *mubaddīl*, *mudhallīl*, *munazzīl*, *munawwīl*, *mufaṣṣīl*, *mujzīl*, *mumhīl*, *mujmīl*). *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 417. Cf. Mīr-Jahānī, *Ravāyih al-nasamāt* 107–108.

109 Ḥasanzāda Āmulī proposes the term Paraclete (*fāraqīlūt/faraqīlūt*) as a possible referent. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 418.

110 In some printed versions *zā*.

In three places its Name begins with <i>D</i>	92 از سه جا مصدر اسمش دال ¹¹² است
as at the beginning of a verse in the Sura of the Spoils. ¹¹¹	بر سر آیه ای از انفال است
Its beginning is 17, its end <i>S</i>	93 اولش هفده و آخر سین است
forever in the middle of <i>YS</i> . ¹¹³	متصل در وسط یس است
Its heart is conducive of happinesses varied,	94 قلب او باعث خوشحالیهاست
its nominative and accusative cases all of them light.	فتح و نصبش همگی نور و ضیاست
This comprehends the cause of the letters' effects	95 شامل علت آثار حروف
and all of the letters' cycles. ¹¹⁴	جامع کلی ادوار حروف
The product of its <i>bayyina</i> , [as noted,] is 70,	96 مخرج بینۀ اش هفتاد است
a master principle [to follow].]	این همه قاعده استاد است ¹¹⁵
How happy the heart that grasps such allusions!	97 خرم آن دل که پیابد این رمز
Don't reveal them to just any winker.	نکند فاش رموزات به غمز
'Tyānī, you have elucidated them [enough],	98 ای عیانی چو تو این کشف رموز
have found and disbursed these riches—	کردی و یافتی آن نقد کنوز
now reveal no more of this secret,	99 بیش از این کاشف این راز مباحث
cease to be an informant!	راز پنهان کن و غماز مباحث
It is strictly for those who are worthy,	100 هر که اهلیت این حالش هست
who through prayer attain what has here been described	به دعا حاصل از این قالش هست
But softly now, lest the evil unworthy	101 دم فرو بند که نا اهل شریر
learn of this elite method!	نشود ز این روش خاص خبیر

111 Ḥasanzāda Āmulī here notes a number of Names beginning with either *Dh* or *D*. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 420.

112 In some printed versions *dhāl*.

113 As Ḥasanzāda Āmulī notes, *H* has the value of 17 in the *AḤST* cycle, descending to *S* (the final letter in the Quran), as does *B* (the first letter in the Quran) in the cycle *AJNDh*. *Rumūz-i kunūz* iii, 420–421.

114 I.e., the different letter series used for different prognosticative purposes, including *ABJD*, *ABTTh*, *AYQGh*, *AḤTM*, etc.

115 This line repeats line 57.

It is only by leave of God the Forgiving	۱۰۲ من به توفیق خداوند غفور
that I have revealed to seekers this method,	طالبان را بنمود دستور
have discoursed cryptically on its theory and applications,	۱۰۳ اصل و فرعش بنودم به رموز
distributing freely the wealth of these treasures.	فاش کردم به همه نقد کنوز
Let all with utmost sincerity	۱۰۴ به عیانی همه از صدق و صفا
offer a prayer for 'Iyānī!	بکنند از سر اخلاص دعا

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